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DRAFT

[Opening Logistics - Music, Procession]

Welcome

Welcome family and friends. Please be seated.

The couple-to-be have asked that you please silence and **put away** phones for the next half hour, and be present with us for this ceremony.

We are invited here today to share in an important moment in the lives of:

Michael Rush McAllister and Kasaundra Rae Heiberger.

My name is Geoff; I am a friend of Michael and Kasaundra's. I have long admired them, and it is the honor of a lifetime to stand before you today to wed them with your blessing.

Each of you sitting here has played a role in shaping these two lives before you, and also in witnessing their coming together. Today, we, here, are lucky to come together to sanctify their love under this beautiful, blossoming tree, serenaded by Ben, and by the geese behind me.

Just as you and I would not be here today without Michael and Kasaundra, they too may not be here today without the support of each of us -- of parents, siblings, of families of origin, and families of choice.

So, thank you for having been there for them then, and for being with us here now.

On K&M, Part 1: How I met them.

Marriage does mark a new beginning. But today is as much a celebration of what Michael and Kasaundra have built over the last fifteen -- yes, fifteen -- years.

They met in 2001, long before either of them could claim to know themselves. Kasaundra was a cheer captain, and Michael, importantly, drove a maroon mustang. They could not know that they would spend their next one-and-a-half decades in an epic, loving relationship, spanning various individual accomplishments and varying long distances.

But in these 15 years, Michael and Kasaundra have modeled for our peer cohort how to pursue independent careers while also patiently tending the foundations for an enduring love. Their stability has become our stability. Their strength, our strength. Their love lifts us up.

I asked some of you for a few words, or one metaphor, to describe this couple. Michael's sister Melanie summed this up: "They are the raft that keeps others afloat..." She added "their strength, resilience, and love shows in all they do."

I couldn't agree more. More from others later.

I met Kasaundra when we rode our bicycles from Austin, TX to Anchorage, AK. I can tell you that she is tough as nails. I have seen first hand that nothing stands in the way of her achieving long-term, audacious goals. Even more than this, she can not only achieve audacious goals herself but also, in the meanwhile, she can take care of those next to her. On this ride, she would be known as the team mom, or even occasionally K-Mom-dra.

Not to be outdone, Michael completed this same ride the following year. There is something beautiful about them completing this ride separately, but symmetrically. I might even say it would foreshadow the next decade of their life, as Kasaundra pursued advance degrees in California, and Michael pursued his own in Rhode Island then St. Louis.

Recently, Michael and Kasaundra have arrived at a kind of goal -- finally being in the same place at the same time, for a long time. But they have also arrived at a kind of beginning -- a new commitment to building a shared life together.

On K&M, Part 2: In their own words.

I spent one weekend with Kasaundra, Michael, and Jezebel (their dog) in February, speaking with them about their present and future together. In that weekend, I was able to witness their happy life, and to speak to them about their love. I want to share with you a few things with you from this time.

To Kasaundra, love is like cherry goat cheese ice cream: sweet, savory, tart, and creamy. Put another way, love is when Michael realizes Jezzy is showing him too much attention and so subtly tries to redirect her attention towards Kasaundra.

She admires Michael's passion, the way he shares his lab results with her, excitedly. She believes that Michael now knows her better than she knows herself. She appreciates that they play well, usually "through sarcasm and tickles".

She thinks it's cute that she perceived Michael to get nervous when he proposed -- considering the failure rate approximated 0%. She appreciated that he proposed while they were unpacking groceries, because the "everyday" is precisely where they excel.

Michael will tell you that Kasaundra is, physically, a good sparring partner.

He recalls vividly, early in their relationship, seeing Kasaundra dancing with unbridled joy early. He concludes "She's worth waking up for every morning"

Now, some might say "It's about time, Michael". While it is true that Michael can take his time on important decisions, I will tell you that this method correlates with the seriousness with which he takes this commitment. This woman, this love, above all else, until the end of his days.

Michael deeply appreciates that they have been able to independently flourish while also growing their love.

In fact, both alluded to their garden -- at The Laclede Boyle and Bell community gardens -- as a kind of metaphor for their relationship. They each contribute to their strengths. Michael does most of the manual labor, and Kasaundra the detail-oriented tasks like plot planning and seed planting. Though it should be noted they both share in all these responsibilities.

Together they co-create and co-nurture their small plot of ground.

On K&M, Part 3: In the words of others.

I want to spend just a moment longer to continue to praise this couple, but in your words. I mentioned earlier that I had asked some friends and family for words about the couple.

“Constance... Steady... Steadfast... Resilient... Strong.” These are the words that came up again and again. I would like to mention a few more.

Kasaundra’s sister, Katisha, says “The word that kept coming to mind was ‘balanced’”

Best man Michael, says a “casual way to describe their relationship is ‘ride or die’”; he goes on “I admire most their commitment to one another.”

Bridesmaid Makani, says: “Through PA school, I watched [Kasaundra] struggle with being far away from Michael, and they talked and they had a deal to see each other no less than every 8 weeks. and they stuck to it. and it worked... They talk through their hard stuff and they actively find solutions to work through it without ego or pride.”

She adds: “I love that they have quirky little arguments about stuff I’d never even think to argue about like bacteria resistance or something like that.”

Michael’s brother, Patrick says, “For me, in my ‘(mis)adventures’ in the time they’ve been together it’s nice to look their way and see ‘yeah, okay, someone in the family has it pretty well locked down. It is possible!’”

Friend, Kat, says: “Something Kasaundra showed me, and that I deeply appreciate, is a model for loving someone faithfully and devotedly amidst their absence. In the years Kasaundra was long-distance from Michael, she unwaveringly loved him with her words, heart, and mind.”

Michael’s Sister, Julia, says: “I admire most... their adventurous determination in keeping love light and fun, yet strong.”

Finally, Maid of Honor Kasie says: “I love that Kasaundra and Michael have a laid back type of love-they make it look easy. Being in their presence is just comfortable and homey-feeling! There’s no need to impress anyone with their love.”

On Marriage

Now I will confess, as already acknowledged by others, that I learn from Kasaundra and Michael perhaps more than I know myself, about how to build a committed, productive, and loving partnership. Yet I feel compelled to say something about marriage itself, since this is, after all, a wedding.

Even with firm foundations, marriage may be the most challenging human-to-human relationship. It is the ultimate choice. No ceremony can guarantee a marriage. A casual survey of our lives shows us that no piece of paper, nor even a commitment before God, can guarantee a marriage.

What I understand you to be doing today, Kasaundra, and Michael, is making a commitment to make a choice, every day. Each day, every day, from now until your final day, you will choose one another. Even -- and, of course, especially -- when it is hard.

Each day, you can **choose** to redouble your commitment to relationship-deepening behaviors. Each day, you can make **new choices** around those behaviors that interrupt the fullest flourishing of your partnership.

You can choose to support and believe in one another. You can choose to nurture a deep and abiding friendship -- one that evolves as each of you do.

You can choose to actively and peaceably **resolve** conflict -- which will arise -- and to **repair** when conflict erupts past your capacity. You can choose to invest the time to dream together, to plan together, and then to co-execute your life together.

And while you do all of this, we have a choice, too. Each of us sitting here today can also choose to be an active and engaged member of your beautiful lives -- of your still yet burgeoning partnership. **We** can choose to support you. We can choose to listen to you, to love you as we know how, through any hardship, to celebrate with you as you arrive at new milestones -- a new garden harvest, a new home, children, the so many adventures yet to come, and beyond.

Even sometimes we may choose to remind you of this commitment that you made here today.

Luckily this is a choice you have become accustomed to making. Lucky, indeed. Because while marriage may be the most challenging relationship, I also believe it has the most potential -- to generate meaning for each of you, and for all those you touch. For your family that is now, before you, and your family that will become.

Your marriage can be a home — a seat of comfort and security — not wed to place. It can provide a kind of flourishing, a set of adventures, not remotely possible, not as colorful or as fun, without a consistent complicit partner, a sounding board, and co-creator.

Your love already is, but will ever more become, **literal** foundation. You are the first villagers in your village. My highest hope for you is that your partnership, and its expanding village becomes your deepest source of pride.

While this pride will take work, the first steps may be simple. Kasaundra, your mother Diana, speaks fondly of you and Michael taking dancing lessons together, of your laughter and dancing. She even says she and Gary may take up lessons of their own. She advises you and Michael that marriage need not be different. She says: “Stay friends, continue to dance and laugh. Everything else will fall into place like the rhythm of your hearts.”

Michael and Kasaundra chose a poem to share, which longtime friend Kat will now read.

Kat's Reading

Sonnet 17 of
One Hundred Love Sonnets
BY PABLO NERUDA

I don't love you as if you were a rose of salt, topaz,
or arrow of carnations that propagate fire:
I love you as one loves certain obscure things,
secretly, between the shadow and the soul.

I love you as the plant that doesn't bloom but carries
the light of those flowers, hidden, within itself,
and thanks to your love the tight aroma that arose
from the earth lives dimly in my body.

I love you without knowing how, or when, or from where,
I love you directly without problems or pride:
I love you like this because I don't know any other way to love,
except in this form in which | I am not | nor are you,
so close that your hand upon my chest is mine,
so close that your eyes close with my dreams.

Invitation to Vows

Thank you, Kat.

Michael and Kasaundra - You each are thorough, meticulous, and reliable. **Be thorough** in rewarding each other for any occasion, or none. You are each fiercely loyal to your friends and loved ones; **be each other's closest ally**. As a couple, you have been foundational and inspirational to so many - **Always seek to inspire one another** as you do all of us.

Do you now have vows you wish to share with each other?

Kasaundra's Vow

Michael: You are my best friend, strength tester, playmate, confidant, supporter, co-adventurer, and the love of my life.

Over the past 15 years our love has matured as we have grown up and experienced life together. Through this time I have learned the more I know you, the more that I love you. I cherish that you are a loyal, honest, and sarcastic man. Your motivation and passion for your hobbies and work inspire me. I love that you make us laugh everyday and that we nerd out about science and medicine.

I promise to keep exploring life with you, walking hand in hand, communicating and navigating the road that lies ahead. To cherish the quiet moments between life events. To celebrate your successes and lift you up after sorrow. To be your sounding board, your biggest supporter, and your grounding point. To be your friend and lover. I promise to give my best to us. I can't see what our adventure will bring next. I love you!

Michael's Vow

Kasaundra:

I fell in love with you because of your smile, warmth, sincerity, kindness and how you love to dance. I am the person standing before you today because of this. You've made me a better person and partner.

Every single day you nurture my heart and my spirit. You make life wonderful, complicated, and worth living. Why it took you 15 years to accept my hand as your partner in life, I'll never understand. Kasaundra, I've loved you for 15 years and that love endures today, stronger than ever. And I only expect my love to grow.

Here is what I vow to you (and Jezebel):

I vow...

To share my life with you.

To be kind and humble in all things.

To always have the best garden in Saint Louis or wherever next we call home.

To always listen and communicate no matter how big or small the topic.

To be whatever you need as you face life's challenges.

To become one with the water.

To hold you tenderly in moments of happiness and sadness.

I vow to love you unconditionally.

Thank you for guarding my heart and my life. I'm humbled that you allow me to do the same.

Rings, Kiss, Invitation

[Ask for Ring from Kasie, then Michael Rowe]

Michael, I give you this ring,
as a symbol of our marriage,
for today and tomorrow,
and for all the days to come.

Kasaundra, I give you this ring,
as a symbol of our marriage,
for today and tomorrow,
and for all the days to come.

Kasaundra, do you take Michael to be your
lawfully wedded husband?

Michael, do you take Kasaundra to be your
lawfully wedded wife?

Do you promise to honor him in love, to
comfort him in difficulty, and to put your full
and complete trust in him, so long as you both
shall live?

Do you promise to honor her in love, to
comfort her in difficulty, and to put your full
and complete trust in her, so long as you both
shall live?

Do you promise to respect him, to share your
life and your dreams, to build with him a home
and a community that is a place of love,
happiness, commitment, and growth?

Do you promise to respect her, to share your
life and your dreams, to build with her a home
and a community that is a place of love,
happiness, commitment, and growth?

Do you promise to be a companion to him in
all of his successes and failures, his happiness
and sadness, to always give to him your
unwavering support and above all else, the
freedom to be Michael?

Do you promise to be a companion to her in
all of her successes and failures, her happiness
and sadness, to always give to her your
unwavering support and above all else, the
freedom to be Kasaundra?

By the power vested in me by the state of Missouri, I declare you husband and wife.

I invite you to begin your married life with a kiss.

Please help me in welcoming the new Mr. & Mrs. Michael McAllister.

[Bride and Groom Exit up aisle]

Please join us for the reception at **Squires** at Park & 18th where we'll continue the festivities.

[Exit]